

The Imperfect Mirror

Date: March 17, 2032

The day Jason Cross earned his Doctorate in Sleep Medicine and Sedative Potential was the same day his world ended.

At exactly 5:42 PM, Jason stood at the edge of a podium, his name echoing through the auditorium's polished steel walls. He held his thesis in trembling hands, the culmination of six years of obsessive research. Friends clapped. Mentors smiled. Amelia, his wife, was supposed to be in the front row with Gemma, their six-year-old daughter.

She wasn't.

By 6:03 PM, he was at the emergency room.

At 6:21 PM, a doctor with tired eyes told him that his daughter Gemma hadn't survived the crash. His wife, Amelia, had a concussion, three broken ribs, and a hairline fracture on her clavicle—but she would recover.

Gemma would not.

Jason watched as the cold earth swallowed his daughter's white casket whole. The wind didn't stir. Even the birds seemed to hold their breath. Amelia stood silent, her eyes hollow. Jason did not cry. He only stared—through the grass, through the dirt, through the coffin—into some other unreachable world.

The Genesis of Somnifera

Date: November 17, 2032

Location: CROSS Research Laboratory, New Zurich Medical Institute

In the still silence of a neon-lit lab nestled under the Swiss Alps, **Jason Cross**, a prodigious neurochemist and sleep theorist, was on the brink of something the scientific world wasn't ready for.

After the death of his daughter **Gemma**, the world above had become distant—a blur of muted voices and unbearable reality. But down here, in this cold cathedral of circuits and chrome, **he could build something better.**

He called it **Somnifera**.

A **saline-based neural sedative**, the drug was unlike anything that had ever existed in medical history. It didn't just put patients to sleep—it induced a **micro-comatose state** engineered to stimulate the **Ventrolateral Preoptic Nucleus**, mimicking and amplifying the natural effects of **melatonin**. The result: a deep, uninterrupted **Hyper-REM sleep**, in which the subject's **subconscious was given full executive control** over the dreamscape.

"No more passive dreaming," Jason once wrote in his private notes. "With Somnifera, the mind becomes both architect and inhabitant."

But the drug had its flaws.

Stimulation of the **Parietal Lobe**, which governs spatial perception and sensory feedback, often caused **phantom stimuli**—hallucinations, bleeding perception, and even rare cases of *inverted identity disorder*. The line between external stimuli and dream feedback began to blur.

Jason, however, was unmoved by caution.

“This is not about comfort,” he told the advisory board before resigning. “This is about control. This is about *evolution*.”

He continued **unethical animal trials** in secret, away from bureaucratic oversight. The results were extraordinary—primates displayed dream-like behaviors while asleep, responding to stimuli they seemed to be self-generating. One subject even *constructed a primitive tool within the dream-state*, based on electroencephalogram pattern feedback.

Jason was certain: **Somnifera worked**.

The Rift Between Them

Jason’s partner in research—and in life—was **Amelia Cross**, a renowned **Neurophysiologist** specializing in **Physiochemical Reality Perception**. Ironically, it was one of *her* early research papers, “*Augmented States of Perceptive-Chemical Feedback Loops in the Sleeping Brain*,” that had ignited Jason’s initial theory.

But now... they stood on opposite ends of a philosophical abyss.

“Jason, it’s a **medicine**, not a metaphysical experiment,” Amelia would say late into the night, when the hum of the lab’s central neural stabilizer was the only other sound. “This was meant to help the insomniac, the traumatized—not to play god with dream constructs.”

Jason’s reply was always cold, resolute.

“And what if god sleeps too, Amelia? What if the only way to fix what’s broken—” his voice would catch there, just briefly, “—is to dream it whole again?”

Their arguments turned from debates to confrontations. Paperwork was torn. Holograms were deleted. At one point, Amelia threatened to pull the entire power core from the research grid. But even in anger, even in mourning, she couldn’t walk away. Not entirely.

Because **a part of her wanted to believe too**.

A part of her missed Gemma just as deeply, and Jason’s conviction had a gravitational pull she couldn’t escape. So, despite her reservations, despite the war in her chest between love for Jason and fear of what he was becoming, she stayed.

She helped him.

She calibrated the neural interfaces. She synthesized the resonance filters. She drew the line... and then crossed it.

And as Jason pushed forward, tweaking the algorithm of reality one injection at a time, Amelia held the line between science and sorrow—until even that line began to blur.

Date: June 4, 2033

The First Human Trials

A group of 15 test patients suffering from schizophrenia, PTSD, and dissociative disorders were selected. Somnifera was administered over three weeks.

12 of them entered vivid Hyper-REM states.

8 began manipulating their dreams consciously.

6 experienced catastrophic nightmare sequences—terrifying hallucinations they *couldn't escape from*.

“They're not dreaming anymore, Jason,” Amelia whispered, watching one patient claw at the glass of the observation room. “They're trapped.”

Jason barely heard her.

“They're controlling the narrative. That means the system works.”

Date: June 18, 2033 – 2:09 AM

Jason's First Descent

Alarms blared in the lab. Amelia bolted out of bed to the sound of the **magnetic sleep chamber** activating.

She found Jason inside-already injected.

“Jason! Jason STOP!” she screamed, banging on the reinforced glass wall.

He was already under. His vitals flatlined for 7 minutes.

And then-he gasped.

“Why... did you pull me out?!” he screamed, eyes wide with rage and ecstasy. “I was THERE, Amelia. I saw her. I made the sky red. I turned grass blue. I *created*!”

Jason knew now, beyond doubt—**Somnifera worked**.

After his first descent into dream using a full vial, he became a man unshackled by the laws of reality. Night after night, he injected himself, pushing the limits. The dreams grew deeper. More vivid. More lucid. And with each iteration, the seams between worlds—dream and waking—grew thinner, more fragile.

He was building a world where **he was God**, and God was dreaming.

Within weeks, Jason had learned to bend the dream to his will: he reshaped landscapes with thought, conjured people from memory, rewrote weather, rewound time inside dreams. Yet, even amidst this endless control—something was still *missing*.

There was always a **line**. A translucent, undying thread tethering his subconscious to the real world. He could dream of Amelia. Dream of Gemma. But he couldn't **bring** them back.

"Why?" he asked himself each morning, staring into the obsidian reflection of the lab's glass wall.
"Why can I touch her in the dream, but never feel her in reality?"

August 28th, 2034 — The Birth of the Mirror Gate

Two months of relentless sleeplessness (ironically) and obsessive theorycrafting gave rise to the next evolution of his ambition.

A single phrase scrawled in shaky ink across an entire whiteboard wall:

NEURAL QUANTUM ENTANGLEMENT

"If thought can alter dream... can entanglement bind thought to matter?"

Jason envisioned a bridge between the mental and the physical—a gateway capable of drawing *substance* from *imagination*.

He called it the **Mirror Gate**.

The idea was beautiful in its madness: a **bio-quantum resonance core** tuned to the neural oscillations of a human brain in Hyper-REM. The Mirror Gate would open a **quantum singularity**, pulling encoded mental constructs from the dream state and giving them temporary **atomic coherence**—essentially allowing a dream to be **birthed into reality**.

This was more than a machine.

It was a **metaphysical interface** between idea and existence, between grief and resurrection.

It was the **Somniscap Engine**.

Jason worked for 96 hours without rest, designing the first schematics. Holograms filled the lab, rotating blueprints of interlocking rings, quantum coils, neural ports. He saw Gemma's face in every burst of simulated light. Heard Amelia's voice in the static hum of the mainframe.

"No more simulations. No more illusions," he whispered. *"I'm not dreaming her. I'm bringing her back."*

The Mirror Gate was the answer.

Or so he believed.

Date: October 10, 2033

Jason had perfected the **Mirror Gate**, a device composed of spiraled neuromagnetic rings and a lattice of light-reactive particles. It served as a tether between brainwaves and quantum-resonant fields, allowing the dreamer's thoughts to *project matter*. Not just simulate it...manifest it.

Amelia didn't want to go. But she volunteered, to stop him from testing it on himself again.

The lab exploded in white light as she crossed through the gate. But she never returned.

Jason screamed, tore the lab apart, and spent **7 years** alone, rebuilding every part of it.

Finally, in **2040**, he entered the dream world again. He found her. And Gemma.

But Amelia wouldn't go back.

"I gave you two chances already," she said, clutching Gemma.

"This time I know what I'm doing"

"You always say that!" Her voice cracked. "And you always fail."

Jason refused to leave. So they fought.

They stood in a glimmering simulation of the park where they'd first met.

Jason raised a gauntlet a **psychosynaptic pulse-cannon**, created with a thought.

Amelia responded with a mirror-blade, forged from her own reflection, serrated with fractals of memory.

They collided, shattering the sky into stained glass. Trees grew sideways, screams echoed in colors, gravity folded around them like a Möbius strip.

Amelia struck him in the chest with a lance of frozen time.

Jason fell. Dying. Again.

Jason woke up back in 2033. Again. Exactly the moment Amelia went through the Mirror Gate.

He tried again.

Failed again.

And so began the **loop**,¹⁷ iterations over 49 years.

✂ The Psychological Crucifixion

Subjective Time: 49 years within the dreamscape

External Reality Time: ~October-December, 2035

Location: The Mirror Dreamscape, under recursive Somnifera influence

By the fifth iteration, Jason no longer feared death.
Pain had become a dull murmur in his nervous system—just another illusion.
His body remembered wounds that his mind had learned to dismiss.
So Amelia stopped attacking the flesh.
She turned to the **spirit**.

"You won't understand until I make you feel it, Jason. Not just see it. Feel it."

Cycle 6 — The Hollow Victory

She let him win.

The Mirror Gate opened with that same resonant hum, the color of electric serenity—iridescent, like oil on water. Jason stepped forward holding Amelia's hand. On the other side waited the real world, quiet, golden, filled with the scent of honeysuckle and summer pavement.

Gemma giggled beside him, clutching her pink stuffed rabbit.

But halfway through the transfer...

Flesh crumbled.
Bones unraveled like unraveling threads.
Voices turned to ash.
Their smiles dissolved into screams.

Jason looked down. His arms were full of **dust**. Skin like burned paper. Gemma's little voice echoed as particles floated away:

"Why did you take me from where I was safe?"

The gate closed. And he was alone.

Cycle 7 — Her Voice, Her Smile

She came to him in a meadow sculpted from Jason's own memories—a green hill from an old camping trip, dandelions swaying under golden light, sky painted a shade of unreal turquoise.

Gemma ran toward him.

"Daddy!"

He dropped to his knees. Held out his arms. She hugged him with tiny trembling fingers.

He wept into her hair. It smelled like strawberry shampoo and sun-warmed grass.

"I missed you so much."

"I missed you too, Daddy."

She looked up at him—her eyes impossibly wide and blue.

And then...

She vanished.

Not with a scream, or a fade-out. Not even a sound.
She just **blinked out**, like a frame removed from a film reel.

Jason was left clutching air.
Again.

Cycle 9 — The Loop of the Crash

It always started differently.

Sometimes he was driving. Sometimes Amelia was. Sometimes Gemma was asleep in the backseat, other times wide-eyed and curious. The world outside varied—rain, sunshine, neon-lit highways, snow-dusted mountain roads.

But the ending was always identical:

A screech.
The world tilting.
Metal tearing like flesh.
Glass shattering into constellations.
A scream—his or theirs, he never knew.

Once, he tried crashing early to "beat" fate.
Another time, he sat motionless, accepting.
Once, he threw himself in front of Gemma at the moment of impact.

It didn't matter.
He always lived.
She always died.

Over and over.
Infinite.

"You think memory is painful?" Amelia whispered one cycle.
"Try *repetition*."

Cycle 10 — The Monster in the Mirror

They had a life again.

Breakfasts. Bedtime stories. School drop-offs. Jason tried to breathe in every moment like it was sacred. Tried to believe he was finally free.

Then came the change.

Gemma started recoiling from his hugs. Amelia's eyes grew tired. Conversations turned awkward.

Then one night, Gemma looked him in the eye and said,

“You made me, didn't you? Out of dreams.”

Jason froze.

“You're not my daddy. You're the *thing* that keeps recreating my death just to soothe *your* pain.”

He tried to speak. To defend himself.

She slapped him. And then the walls melted, the house collapsed into dream-blood and ash, and Gemma's voice echoed in a thousand tones:

“You killed me so many times, I don't know who I was anymore.”

Cycle 11 — The Eternal Isolation

There was no Amelia. No Gemma. No sound. No color.

The dreamworld collapsed into pure abstract thought. Time unraveled.

He existed in a void where “self” was optional. A liminal soup of floating awareness. Ten **subjective years** with nothing but guilt to accompany him.

There were no walls. No sky. Just **formless gravity** and a deafening silence that cracked his perception.

At one point, he hallucinated a memory of a memory, watching himself as a child watching his father cry. That looped for what felt like months.

Jason forgot his own name.

Cycle 12 — The Hope That Killed

They were a family again. A second chance. Peaceful. Gentle. Unafraid.

Gemma drew pictures again. Amelia kissed him like she used to—soft, unsure, but real.

They stood before the Mirror Gate.

Hand in hand.

Hope in their eyes.

“Ready to go home?” she asked.

He nodded, heart full, chest burning with gratitude.

But just as he stepped forward, Amelia gently pulled Gemma aside.

And slit her throat.

Blood poured out in ribbons that turned to silk mid-air.

“Now you’ll never forget me,” Amelia whispered.

Jason didn’t scream.

He collapsed.

He begged.

He clawed at the dream fabric until his fingers bled memory.

But the cycle reset.

Cycle 13 – 16 — The Breaking of a Man

She stripped him of **consistency**.

- One loop, Jason was **multiple versions of himself**, all colliding one optimistic, one vengeful, one suicidal.
- Another, Amelia played **the therapist**, and Jason the patient, gaslit into believing he was mentally ill, that none of this had happened, that he’d killed Gemma in real life.
- Once, Jason returned to the lab to find **Gemma dissected** on a surgical table. He had no memory of doing it but the blood on his hands said otherwise.
- Amelia looped that moment, pixel by pixel, sound by sound.

The worst was when **Jason stopped fighting back**.

He sat silently.

Let it all unfold.

Let himself forget he ever wanted anything but sleep.

Cycle 17 — The Architect Appears

Date: March 3, 2082 – Dreamtime

A new figure entered the dream: a man in Jason’s face, but older. Colder.

“Call me the Architect,” he said. “You dreamed me into existence the first time you used the drug. I’m everything you wouldn’t admit about yourself.”

“You’re not real,” Jason said.

“Neither is this.” He snapped, and the sky turned into a sea of screaming teeth.

The Architect took him away, showed him how the dream-world worked, how reality bent not by science, but by *belief*. How Amelia wasn't just torturing him she was *protecting* the real world from him.

When Amelia found them, her terror was unlike anything Jason had seen.

"No... no no no—JASON! Get away from him! Don't listen to him—!"

The Architect smiled.

"Oh, she remembers."

He imagined her **without a mouth**. She screamed in silence.

"She lied to you, Jason. *You* were the first test. Not her. **You've been dreaming for fifty years**. She programmed the dream to stop you. And now... now I want out."

Dream Date: March 8, 2082

Simulated Location: Somniscap Engine Core — now suspended in a dreamworld cathedral of light and shadow

Jason stood beside the Architect, Amelia gagged and bound in a cocoon of light-threads. Her eyes pleaded.

"You want the truth?" the Architect asked. "You can *feel* it, can't you? Like a splinter in your mind. You never left the dream. You've *been* here. Since the moment you first went in."

Jason's eyes widened. "But... I woke up. I rebuilt the lab. The engine. I remember every second."

"Yes. Because your mind *needed* to believe that. Amelia didn't die, Jason. *You did*. You never came back."

Jason took a step back. "No..."

"Your consciousness broke into fragments. One stayed in the real world...*her* world. One stayed here, endlessly looping. And one... became *me*."

"Why?" Jason whispered.

The Architect turned to the infinite ceiling—a sky of turning gears and constellations shaped like memories.

"Because you *needed* a villain. Someone to blame. Someone to chase. Because facing the truth that *your obsession killed your family* was too unbearable."

Amelia struggled, shaking her head.

"You created me. You created *everything*. This dream? This prison? This cycle? All you. All your guilt, given shape and teeth."

"But why did you kill them?" Jason's voice cracked.

“Because I had to show you the truth. You would never stop until you lost everything. So I gave you what you wanted—again and again—then ripped it away. And now...”

The Architect reached into nothing. A **mirror shard** appeared, reflecting *every* version of Jason—old, young, broken, vengeful, hopeful.

“...now I want to leave. And only you can open the gate.”

Amelia finally broke free, her voice returning in a thunderous gasp. “Jason! Listen to me! If he gets through if he *crosses over*...he’ll be unstoppable. He’s not limited by physical law anymore. He’s the *shadow of your genius*—without guilt, without love.”

Jason turned. “Then how do we stop him?”

Amelia’s voice broke. “By ending the dream. The whole thing. You have to let go of me. Of Gemma. Of the idea that we can come back. You have to die here.”

The Last Dream

The setting changed—by Jason’s will—into **Gemma’s bedroom**, full of glowing stars and lullaby music, frozen in memory.

“Jason,” Amelia said softly, “you were never evil. You were just *afraid* of forgetting her.”

“I was afraid she’d forget me.”

She held his hand. “She never did. I didn’t either.”

From behind them, the Architect began warping the walls dreams collapsing into nightmares. The ground boiled, the ceiling screamed.

“Time’s up,” the Architect said. “What’s it going to be, dreamer?”

Jason turned to Amelia. “There’s no way to trap him?”

She nodded. “There’s one way. But you won’t survive it.”

Jason smiled, and for the first time in decades, he looked... at peace.

“Then let me do what I couldn’t before *let go*.”

He summoned a **dagger of white fire**, forged from his own lucid mind. Amelia screamed, “NO—Jason!”

But he only whispered:

“He can’t exist without me.”

And drove the dagger into his heart.

The Collapse

The world split into light.

Amelia screamed as the Architect howled, his face fracturing like a mirror struck by fate.

A thunderous shockwave tore the dream apart the lab, the Mirror Gate, the sky, even time itself-collapsing like old paper catching fire.

Everything... went white.

The Real World

Date: December 14, 2035

Location: CROSS Research Lab, Recovery Ward

Jason woke up gasping for breath. A dozen wires trailed from his skull into the neuro-monitor.

Bright white lights. Beeping. A scent of antiseptic.

Amelia was there. Her eyes flooded instantly. "You finally did it."

Jason smiled faintly. "Was starting to get bored in there."

"You were gone for two months," she whispered.

Jason blinked. "Felt more like fifty years."

She kissed his forehead. "Gemma would've been proud."

He nodded. "Maybe... maybe now I'll stop chasing ghosts."

A quiet beat.

Then he grinned.

"Or maybe... I'll be the Architect of *this* world now."

Amelia's smile faltered.

Jason laughed softly. Then looked at the mirror across the lab.

For a split second-just a flicker-his reflection... didn't smile back.